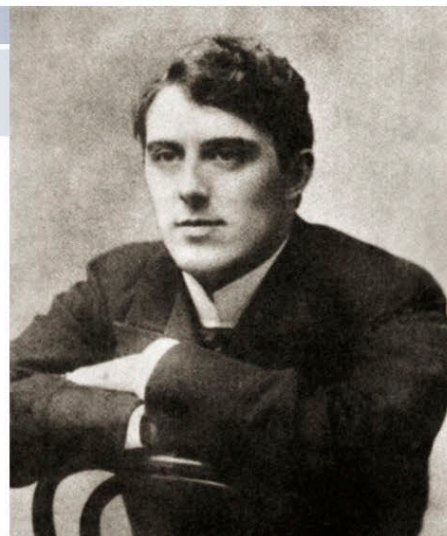




COUNT LOUIS HAMON ("CHEIRO," 1866–1936)

Reading the stars

Born William John Warner, the Irish palmist and astrologer adopted the name Count Louis Hamon, but was often known as Cheiro. After studying chiromancy (Cheiro took his nickname from the alternative spelling, cheiromancy) with gurus in India, he set up a practice in London. His high-profile clients included writers and wits Mark Twain and Oscar Wilde, statesman William Gladstone, actress Sarah Bernhardt, and the Prince of Wales. Famously, Cheiro read the palm of William Pirrie, whose shipyard built the *Titanic*, and is said to have told him, "You will find yourself in a fight for your life," which some have interpreted as a prediction of the *Titanic* disaster.



▲ Fortune-telling

For centuries the practice of palm reading was kept alive by Romany fortune-tellers, and such chiromancy was the inspiration for this 19th-century painting by German artist Theodor Leopold Weller.